Composition The following points can be noted in context of the composition (membership) of the erstwhile Planning Commission:

1. The Prime Minister of India was the chairman of the commission. He/she presided over the meetings of the commission.
2. The commission had a deputy chairman. He/she was the de facto executive head (i.e., full-time functional head) of the commission.
3. Some Central Ministers were appointed as part-time members of the commission.
4. The commission had four to seven full-time expert members.
5. The commission had a member-secretary.

The state governments were not represented in the commission in any way. Thus, the erstwhile Planning Commission was wholly a Centre-constituted body.

Critical Evaluation The erstwhile Planning Commission was originally established as a staff agency with advisory role but in the course of time it had emerged as a powerful and directive authority whereby its recommendations were considered both by the Union and states. The critics had described it as a 'Super Cabinet', an 'Economic Cabinet', a 'Parallel Cabinet', the 'Fifth Wheel of the Coach' and so on.

The following observations were made on the domineering role played by the erstwhile Planning Commission.

1. **First Administrative Reforms Commission (ARC) of India:** The ARC observed: 'Under the Constitution, the ministers, whether in the Centre or the states, are in effect, the ultimate executive authorities. Unfortunately, the Planning Commission has, in some measures, earned the reputation of being a Parallel Cabinet and sometimes, a Super Cabinet'.[12]
2. **K. Santhanam:** This eminent constitutional expert stated that, 'Planning has superseded the federation and our country is functioning like a unitary system in many respects'.[13]
3. **P.V. Rajamannar:** This Chairman of the Fourth Finance Commission observed that there was an overlapping of functions and responsibilities between the erstwhile Planning Commission and Finance Commission in federal fiscal transfers.[14]

National Development Council

On the 1st of January, 2016, it was reported[15] that the Modi government is also going to abolish the National Development Council (NDC) and transfer its powers to the Governing Council of the NITI Aayog. However, till now such a resolution has not been passed.

It must also be noted here that the last meeting (57th) of the NDC was held on the 27th of December, 2012 to approve the 12th Plan (2012–2017).

The NDC was established in August 1952 by an executive resolution of the Government of India on the recommendation of the First Five Year Plan (draft outline). Like the erstwhile Planning Commission, it is neither a constitutional body nor a statutory body.